



George Washington crosses the Delaware River, 1776.

We Teach Students to Look. We Must Also Teach Them How to See.



When we only identify the surface-level facts of an image, we miss the crucial context, perspective, and narrative hidden within.



Passive viewing leads to a superficial understanding of history.



True historical inquiry requires moving beyond simple identification to active analysis. This is the gap we need to bridge.



The Solution: A Framework for Deeper Inquiry

C		Core Identification
A		Action & Observation
S		Significance
E		Examine the Source

The C.A.S.E. framework transforms a simple picture caption into a concise and powerful tool for historical analysis.

C: Core Identification (The Basics)

Every caption must begin with a clear statement of the subject. Establish the fundamental context before diving into analysis.



- **Who:** Identify key figures (e.g., George Washington, Redcoats, Minutemen).



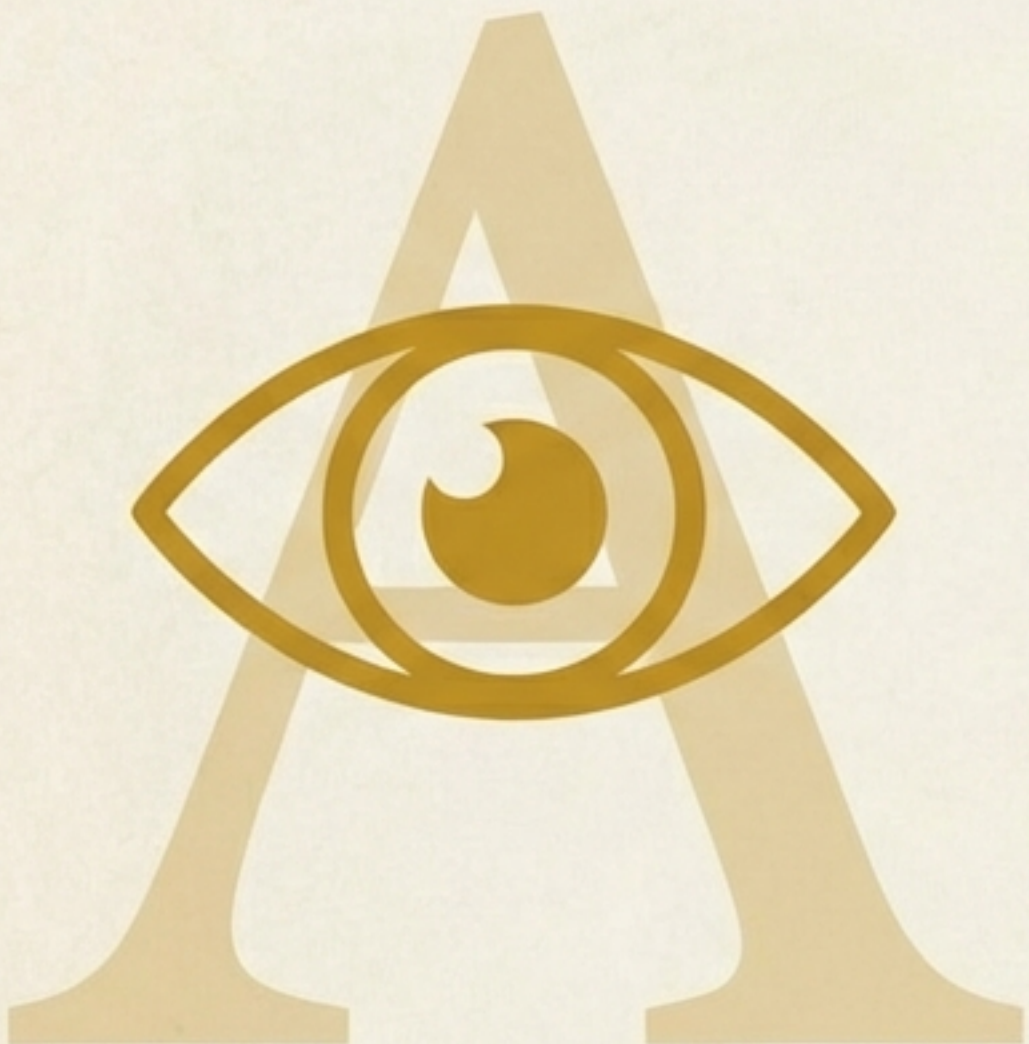
- **What:** Name the event (e.g., The Battle of Yorktown, The signing of the Declaration).



- **When:** Provide the specific date or year.



- **Where:** Mention the location (e.g., Philadelphia, PA; Saratoga, NY).



A: Action & Observation (The Details)

Describe what is physically happening in the image. This step encourages a meticulous examination of the primary source itself, moving from general subject to specific details.

Key Questions to Ask:

- 👁️ • What are the people doing? (e.g., ‘Soldiers are retreating,’ or ‘Delegates are debating.’)
- 👁️ • What specific visual cues are present? (e.g., uniforms, flags, weapons, or weather conditions.)

Notice the tattered clothing of the Continental soldiers, highlighting the lack of supplies at Valley Forge.



S: Significance (The ‘So What?’)

This is where analysis begins. Explain why this moment matters within the larger context of the historical narrative, such as the Revolutionary War.

Key Questions to Ask:

- 💡 How did this event change the course of the war?
- 💡 What larger idea does it represent? (e.g., bravery, hardship, or a turning point).

This victory at Saratoga convinced the French to join the American cause, a decisive turning point in the war.

E: Examine the Source (The Perspective)

History is shaped by those who record it. This step prompts students to think critically about the artist, their purpose, and the medium itself.

Key Questions to Ask:

-  When was this created—during the event or years later?
-  What is the medium? (e.g., engraving, oil painting, photograph).
-  Is the artist trying to make one side look more heroic?
Is this a record or a statement?



From Framework to Analysis: A Case Study

Now, let's apply the C.A.S.E. framework to a single, complex work of art to see how it transforms a simple label into a rich historical analysis.



The "Before": A Basic Identification



Image: *The Death of General Wolfe* by Benjamin West (1770)

Caption: This painting shows the death of British General James Wolfe during the Battle of Quebec in 1759.

Building the Caption: Core & Action

(C) Core Identification:

This painting depicts the death of British General James Wolfe during the Battle of the Plains of Abraham in Quebec in 1759.

(A) Action & Observation:

In the center of the scene, Wolfe is shown dying of his wounds while surrounded by his officers and a contemplative Mohawk warrior, as the British victory over the French is signaled in the background.



Uncovering the Story: Significance & Examination

(S) Significance:

This moment was a major **turning point** because the British capture of Quebec effectively ended French control in North America, setting the stage for British dominance.

(E) Examine the Source:

Although it looks like a photograph of the event, the artist Benjamin West painted this **eleven years later** in an idealized style to make Wolfe look like a heroic martyr rather than providing a realistic military record.

The 'After': A Complete Historical Analysis



The Battle of Quebec

This painting depicts the death of British General James Wolfe during the **Battle of the Plains of Abraham** in Quebec in **1759**. In the center of the scene, Wolfe is shown dying of his wounds while surrounded by his officers and a contemplative Mohawk warrior, as the British victory over the French is signaled in the background. This moment was a major **turning point** because the British capture of Quebec effectively ended French control in North America, setting the stage for British dominance. Although it looks like a photograph of the event, the artist Benjamin West painted this **eleven years later** in an idealized style to make Wolfe look like a heroic martyr rather than providing a realistic military record.

From Simple Label to Historical Insight

Without C.A.S.E.

This painting shows the death of British General James Wolfe during the Battle of Quebec in 1759.



With C.A.S.E.

The Battle of Quebec.

This painting depicts the death of British General James Wolfe during the **Battle of the Plains of Abraham** in Quebec in 1759. In the center of the scene, Wolfe is shown dying of his wounds while surrounded by his officers and a contemplative Mohawk warrior, as the British victory over the French is signaled in the background. This moment was a major **turning point** because the British capture of Quebec effectively ended French control in North America, setting the stage for British dominance. Although it looks like a photograph of the event, the artist Benjamin West painted this eleven years later in an idealized style to make Wolfe look like a heroic martyr rather than providing a realistic military record.

A Tool for Your Classroom and Curation

[Title of Image/Event]

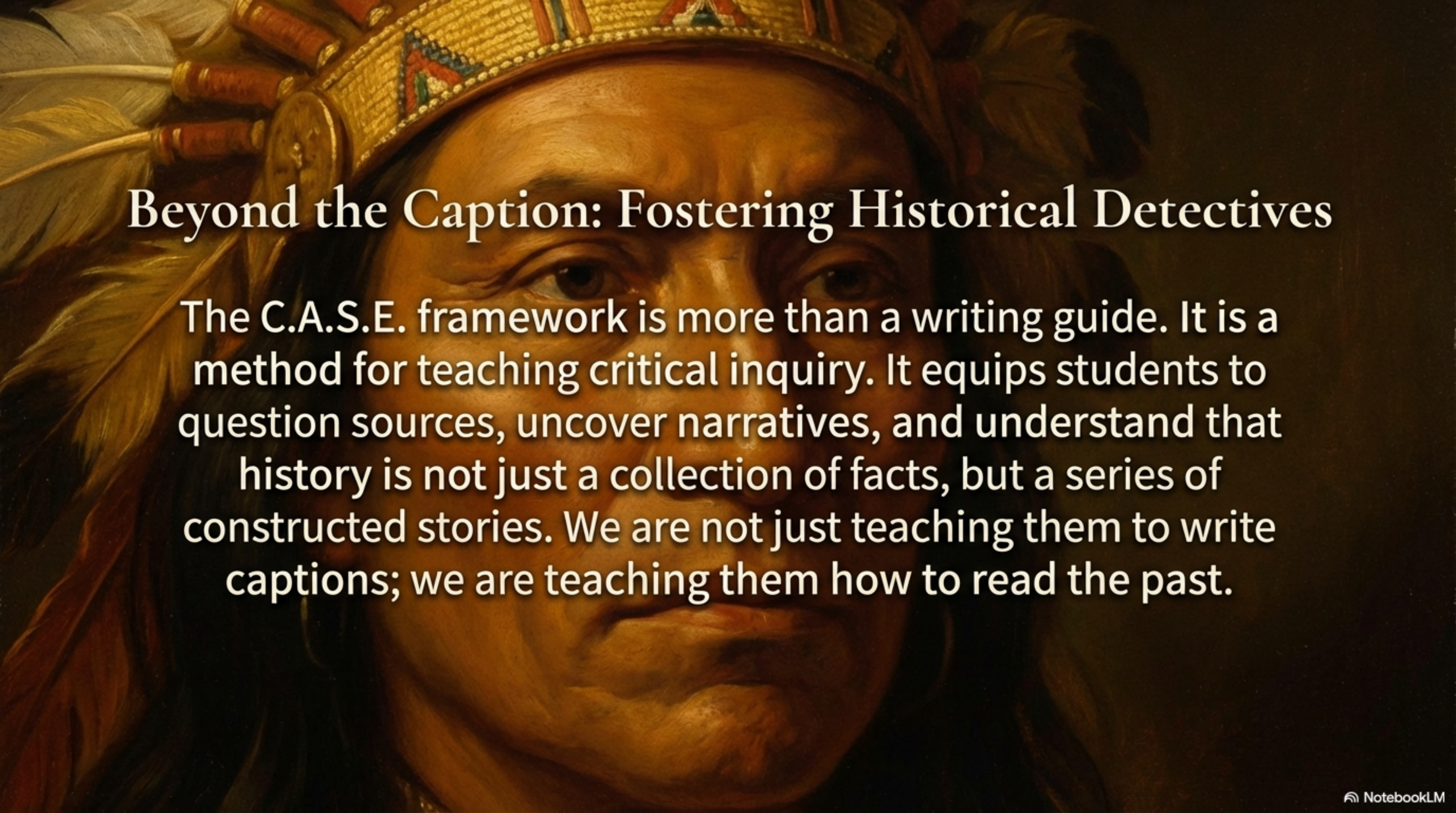
This image depicts [Who] during [Event] in [Year].

In the scene, you can see [Action/Detail].

This moment was significant because [Reason].

This [Type of Art] was created to show [Perspective/Purpose].

Use this fill-in-the-blank structure to guide analysis and build comprehensive captions.

A close-up portrait of a Native American man, likely a chief, wearing a traditional headdress with a yellow band and feathers. The background is dark and textured.

Beyond the Caption: Fostering Historical Detectives

The C.A.S.E. framework is more than a writing guide. It is a method for teaching critical inquiry. It equips students to question sources, uncover narratives, and understand that history is not just a collection of facts, but a series of constructed stories. We are not just teaching them to write captions; we are teaching them how to read the past.